

A Short Case for Boring Output

Most document generators optimize for visual variety — icons, gradients, accent palettes, rounded corners, illustrated divider graphics. This one does not. It aims to produce the same kind of page, over and over, with as little chrome as the content will tolerate.

Why

The point of a printed page is to be read.

- Every extra color is a decision the reader has to resolve.
- Every rounded corner is a style choice the reader has to accept.
- Every shadow is an attempt to imitate paper that paper itself does not need.

When those decisions aren't yours to make, the reader can just read.

What You Get

ELEMENT	TREATMENT
H1	IBM Plex Serif 700, ink-black, rule below
H2-H4	Same serif family, tighter hierarchy
Body	Lora, 11pt, 1.6 leading, true-italic for emphasis
Code	Dark panel, mono, language tag top-right
Tables	Uppercase-mono header, no vertical borders
Links	Ink-black, underlined
Callouts	Thin black left rule, small mono tag — no bar, no fill
Header	Title left, author right, muted mono
Footer	<code>page / total</code> in mono, centered

How

1. Extract frontmatter with `gray-matter`.
2. Parse Markdown to an mdast tree (`remark-parse` + `remark-gfm`).
3. Transform mdast → hast with `remark-rehype`, running a small `remarkCallouts` plugin along the way.
4. Syntax-highlight with `@shikijs/rehype` using a grayscale theme.

5. Stringify to HTML, wrap in a minimal shell, drive Chromium through Playwright, emit the PDF. Nothing in that list is novel. The novelty, if any, is in what's left out.

Code, For Flavor

TYPESCRIPT

```
const { content, frontmatter } = extractFrontmatter(raw);
const resolved = resolveOptions({ cli, frontmatter, project });
const tree = parseMarkdownToMdash(content);
const body = await mdastToHtml(tree);
const html = wrapInDocumentShell(body, {
  title: resolved.title ?? deriveTitle(inputPath),
  baseUrl: pathToFileURL(dirname(inputPath) + "/").href,
});
```

One call per stage. No theme registry, no plugin API — if a second output format ever arrives, we can add one then.

Callouts

Three types, one source format — a `[!NOTE]`, `[!WARN]`, or `[!SYSTEM]` tag on the first line of a blockquote.

NOTE. Useful context that isn't load-bearing. A quiet aside the reader can take or leave.

WARN. Something the reader must not miss. The left rule is enough signal; the tag above it is enough name.

SYSTEM. A diagnostic, an engineering invariant, or a pre-condition. A dashed rule reads as "from the machine, not the author."

A Note on Checklists

- ~~Five accent palettes.~~
- Grayscale only — no accent color.
- Header and footer in the same typographic voice.
- Cover page (Week 7).

The strikethrough, task list, and nested list all render from a single Markdown source — no special syntax, no escape hatches.

Closing

| *Design is a plan for arranging elements in such a way as best to accomplish a particular purpose.*

— Charles Eames, who knew a thing or two about chairs.

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If a boring page is readable, and a readable page gets read, the boring page has out-performed the interesting one. That is the whole case.